MODULE 00 · AMBITIOUS ENTREPRENEURSHIP

No-Bullshit Entrepreneurship

What kills startups, and what will this course demand from you?

COURSE PATH

00 01 02 03 04 05 06 07 08 09 10 11 12

CHECK-IN · SLIDO OR HANDS

How big could your startup get?

1. A good side income
2. A solid company of 50 people
3. A unicorn
4. The next Google

CHAPTER 1 OF 6

Why now, why you

The companies founded now will shape the next 50 years, so why not yours?

01 **Why now, why you**
02 It has never been easy
03 Speed matters
04 How this course works
05 Wrap-up and check-out
06 Workshop: autopsy your startup before it dies

WHY NOW, WHY YOU

The companies founded now will shape how we see the world for the next

50 years

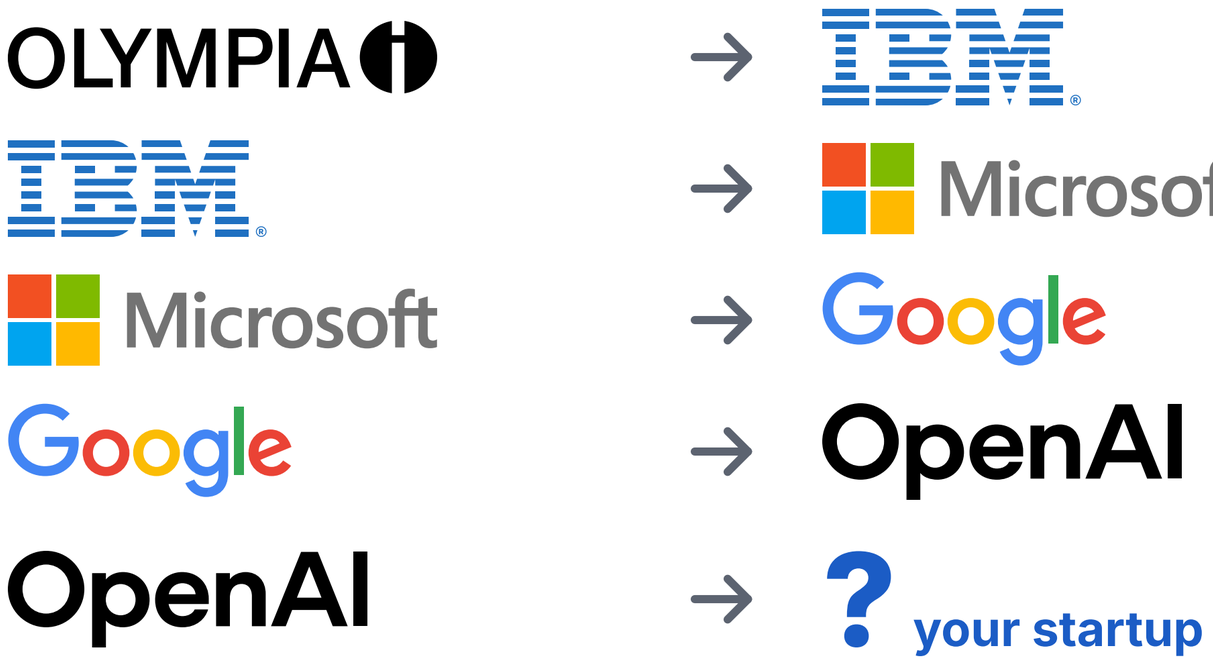
The best time to start in decades.

Maybe in 50 years.

WHY NOW · EVERY TRANSITION

At every transition, a newcomer beat the giants

Nobody saw the next one coming



BASTIAN Legacy slide 20, Bastian's own framing. Logos are trademarks of their owners.

WHERE THE PUCK IS GOING

Nobody knows where the puck is going. Whoever skates there first builds the next big thing.

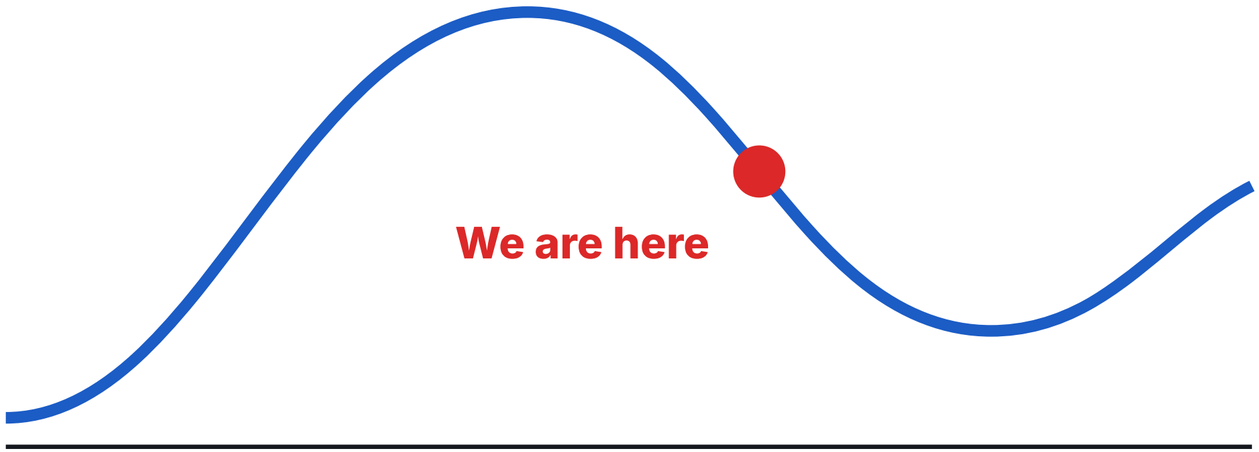
It could be you

BASTIAN After Wayne Gretzky, passing on his father Walter's advice to skate "to where the puck is going" (Gretzky & Reilly, 1990). Bastian's twist (2026-10-19).

WHY NOW · DALIO'S BIG CYCLE, MY READ

Dalio sees a turn coming. I see an opening

Ray Dalio puts us late in a cycle of about 75 years, just before the breakdown



about 75 years, give or take 30 (Dalio)

My read for founders

A productivity crisis clears out slow competitors

Free capital looks for productive outlets

Climate, security and demography need new solutions

FRAMEWORK Dalio, R. (2025). How Countries Go Broke: The Big Cycle. Avid Reader Press. Dalio (2026, March 14), Fortune: "We are now in a new Stage 5". The read for founders is Bastian's, after legacy slide 20.

WHY YOU

They weren't better prepared than you

Age and education when they started

19 **Bill Gates**

Harvard, left without a degree · Microsoft 1975

21 **Steve Jobs**

One semester at Reed College · Apple 1976

25 **Larry Page & Sergey Brin**

Stanford PhD students, never finished · Google 1998

28 **Hasso Plattner**

Engineer, left IBM with four colleagues · SAP 1972

30 **Jensen Huang**

Chip designer, master's from night classes · Nvidia 1993

30 **Werner von Siemens**

Artillery school, no university · Siemens 1847

DATA Ages from birth and founding dates, education at founding. Wikipedia, retrieved 2026-10-19.

BUT…

~~But I'm not an engineer…~~

Yes, you can build it!

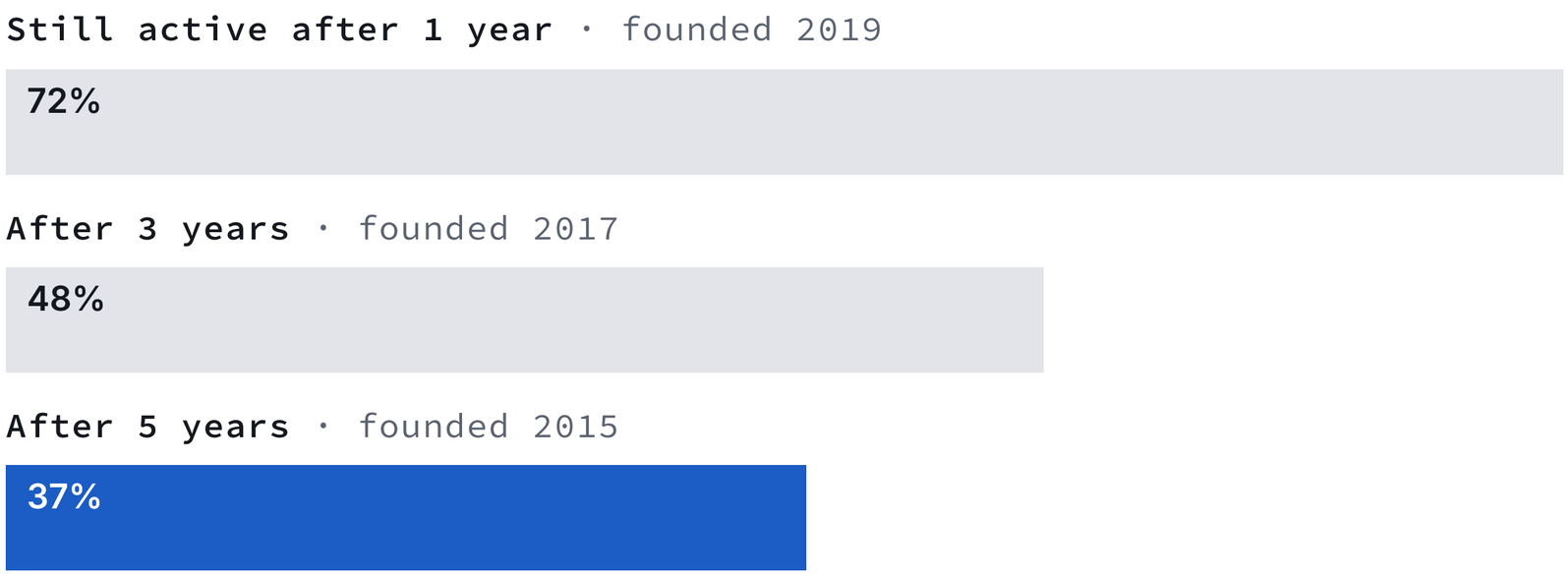
~~But we don't have a GmbH…~~

Yes, you can ship it!

THE BASE RATE

Most new businesses* don't reach year five

Germany, share still active by year founded



* Not all new businesses are startups.

DATA Eurostat, business demography (bd_9bd_sz_cl_r2), Germany, survival rates for reference year 2020, industry, construction and services. Bars to scale.

BE AMBITIOUS

A small idea costs you the same years as a big one. So aim for

the next Google

Aim big. Start narrow.

Facebook began at one campus.

BASTIAN Bastian's view (2026-10-19). Facebook opened to Harvard students only in February 2004. "Start narrow" after Graham (2012), How to Get Startup Ideas.

A TIER LIST OF STARTUP IDEAS

Aim for S. Stay out of the tarpit

Tarpit ideas look easy and die quietly

S Moonshots	The next Google · Industrial capabilities in space
A Unsexy plumbing	Compliance paperwork for small factories · AI-native compliance infrastructure
B Crowded trades	Yet another AI note-taker
C Wrapper zone	Chat with your files · Copilot for dog walkers
D Tarpit ideas	Restaurant & event discovery · An app to plan hangouts with friends · Trading tools for day traders
F	Fridge inventory app · A social network for pet owners · Investing your friends' money on Reddit tips

BASTIAN Bastian's tier list, legacy slide 33. Tarpits, copilots and the Reddit fund after Caldwell and Seibel's YC tarpit videos, the pet network after Graham (2012), space and compliance from YC's Requests for Startups (2026).

NOW YOU · ALONE · 2 MINUTES

Where does your idea land?

! YOUR STARTING POINT

Place it on the tier list

No idea yet? Take a frustration you saw someone fight last month.

→ Write your idea, problem or technology in one line
→ Which tier? Be honest
→ Write the one belief about customers it rests on
→ Like: "Junior HR managers would pay to stop candidates ghosting them"

Output One line, one tier, one belief

Minutes 2

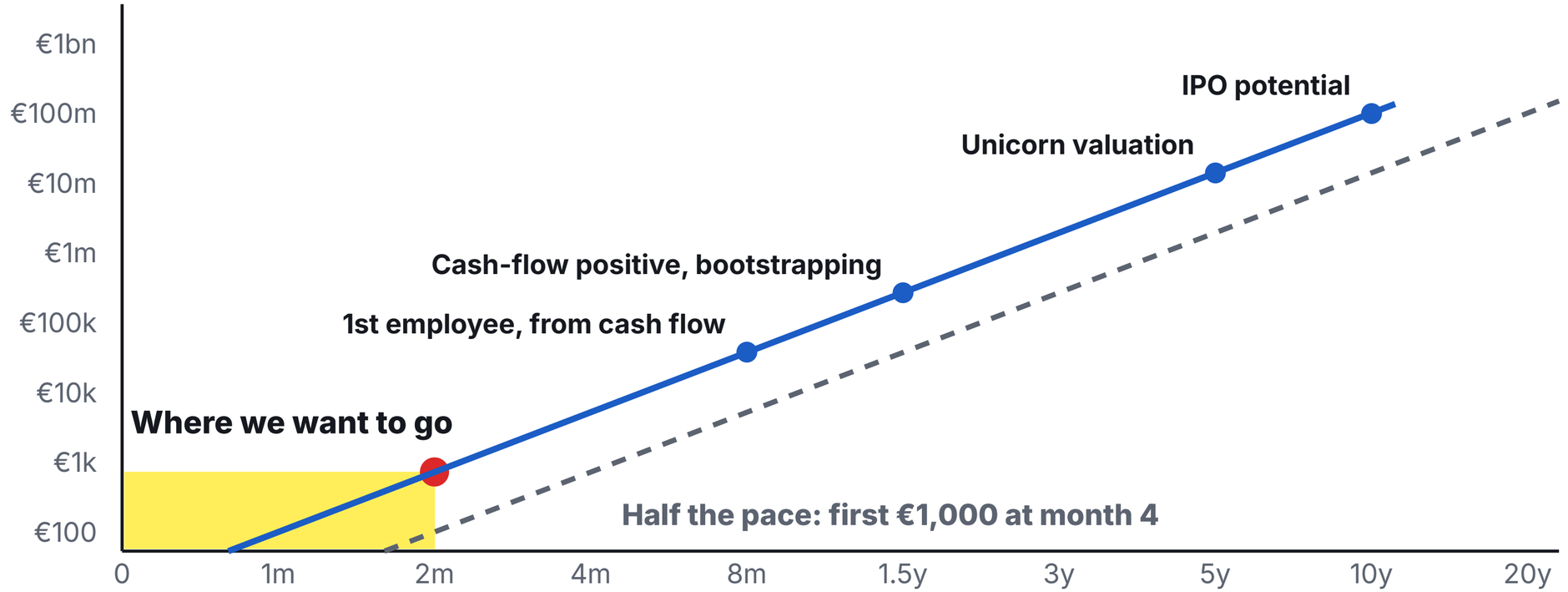
2:00

ILLUSTRATIVE Example belief after legacy slide 182 ("Junior HR managers", not "companies").

REALITY CHECK · THE LONG GAME

Your first €1,000 sets the pace

Revenue and time on log scales. Half the pace now means half the pace later



BASTIAN Legacy slide 32, "not a scientific chart". One straight line on log axes through €1,000 at month two, milestones on the line (2026-10-19).

CHAPTER 2 OF 6

It has never been easy

Every tool made building easier, but finding what people pay for never got easier.

01 ~~Why now, why you~~

02 **It has never been easy**

03 Speed matters

04 How this course works

05 Wrap-up and check-out

06 Workshop: autopsy your startup before it dies

THE #1 KILLER · 101 POST-MORTEMS

"Tackling problems that are interesting to solve rather than those that serve a market need"

42% no market need

The #1 reason.

Not cash. Not competitors.

DATA CB Insights (2019). The top 20 reasons startups fail. 101 startup post-mortems.

"NOW IT'S EASY"

Every new tool made building easier. None made startups easy

"It's getting so cheap to start a startup." Paul Graham, 2005

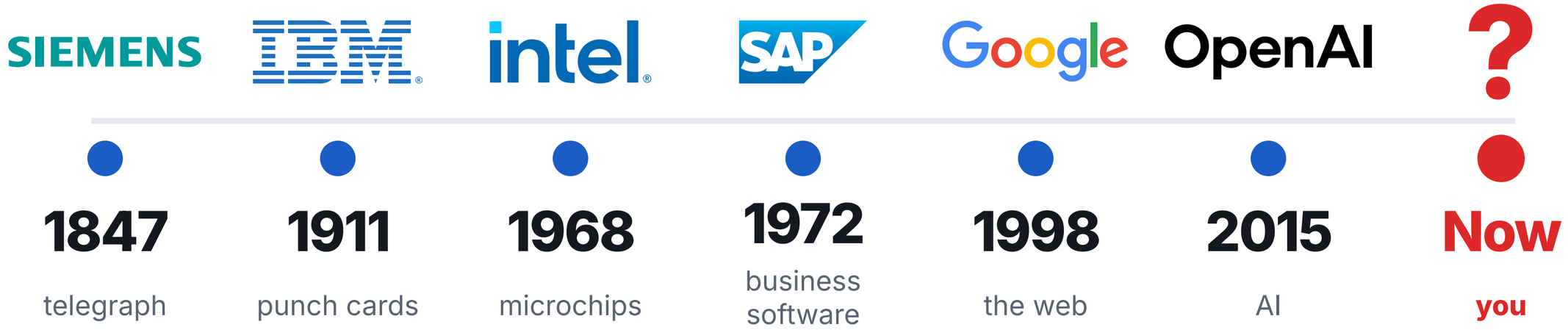


DATA Graham (2005), The Venture Capital Squeeze. Gruber (2005) on DHH's Rails screencast. AWS (2014) on the S3 launch, March 2006. Node.js about page (2012 archive). Bubble No-Code Census (2020). Karpathy (2025) on X. CB Insights (2026), poor product-market fit as root cause in 43% of 431 shutdowns.

THE SKILL NEVER CHANGED

Tech changes. The founder's job doesn't

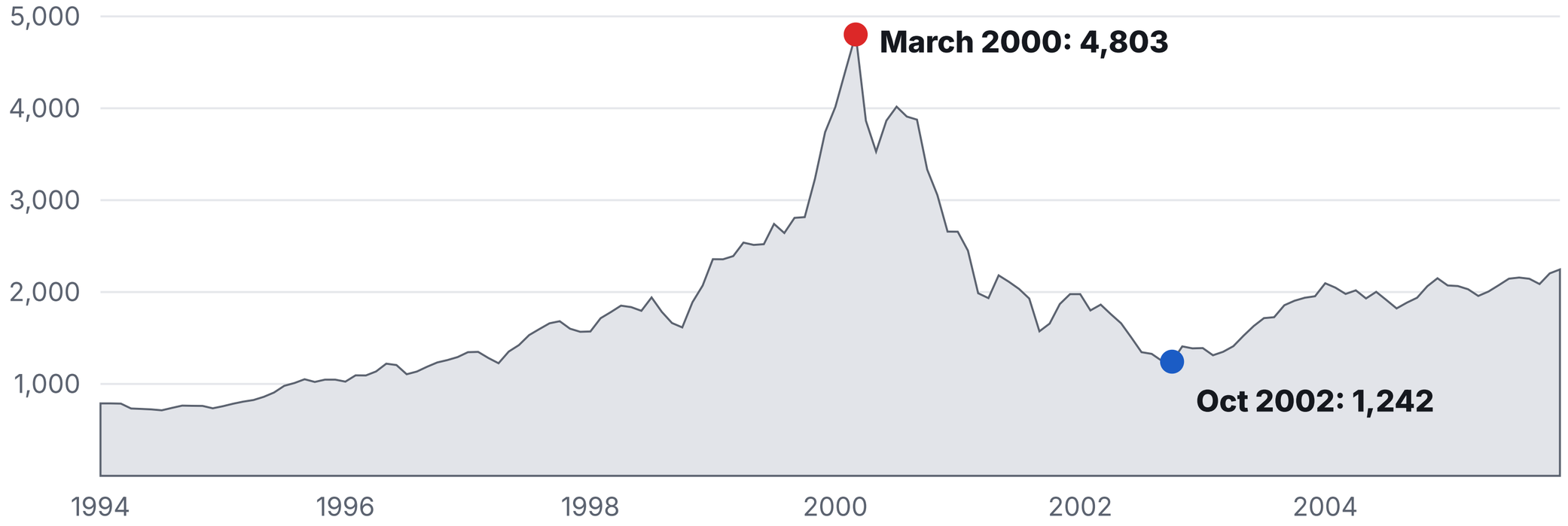
Every wave needed people who turned it into something others pay for



BASTIAN Bastian's framing (2026-10-19). Founding years from Wikipedia, retrieved 2026-10-19. Logos are trademarks of their owners.

BEFORE THE INTERNET

Startups happened before the internet, but they had a problem



DATA Nasdaq Composite index, monthly average of daily closes (NASDAQCOM), via FRED, Federal Reserve Bank of St. Louis. Legacy slide 36, redrawn without logos.

Mistakes aren't a necessary evil. They aren't evil at all. They are an inevitable consequence of doing something new.

Ed Catmull, co-founder of Pixar

BOOK

Creativity, Inc.

Ed Catmull with Amy Wallace, 2014

FRAMEWORK Catmull, E., & Wallace, A. (2014). *Creativity, Inc.* Random House, as quoted by Popova (2014), The Marginalian. Legacy slide 37.

CHAPTER 3 OF 6

Speed matters

You beat the big ones by learning faster, with Build-Measure-Learn and the hierarchy of evidence.

01 ~~Why now, why you~~
02 ~~It has never been easy~~
03 **Speed matters**
04 How this course works
05 Wrap-up and check-out
06 Workshop: autopsy your startup before it dies

THE CASH CONSTRAINT

Your startup is a loop. It runs

cash>0

```
while (cash > 0) {
  learn();
}
```

Every week without learning burns runway.

WORKING WITH CONSTRAINTS

While BMW runs one loop, you can run twenty

No manpower, no money, no time. Also no inertia, no legacy, no politics

BMW

people, money, time

1 iteration — legacy · politics · sign-offs

You

none of that, none of the drag

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12 13 14 15 16 17 18 19 20

BASTIAN Legacy slide 62, Bastian's framing (2026-10-19). The 1 to 20 ratio is an illustration, not a measurement.

THE CORE OF THIS COURSE

Two ideas, two tools

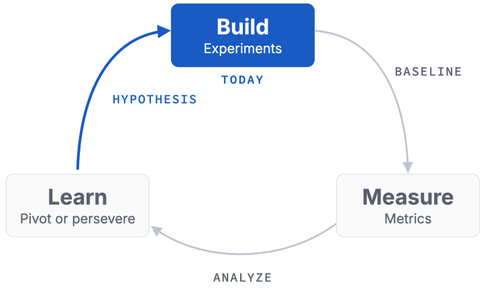
Everything in the next twelve weeks builds on these four

1 Speed matters

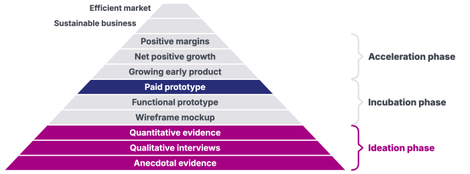
You beat the big ones only by learning faster

2 Validated learning beats everything

Opinions are free. Evidence costs a conversation, a click, a payment



Build-Measure-Learn



Hierarchy of evidence

BASTIAN Bastian's course frame (2026-10-19). Build-Measure-Learn after Ries (2011), the hierarchy of evidence from legacy slides 60 and 61.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS · 4 RANDOMIZED TRIALS

Founders who test like scientists kill bad ideas sooner

759

startups in four randomized trials

+9.8

points more ideas terminated

+€7k

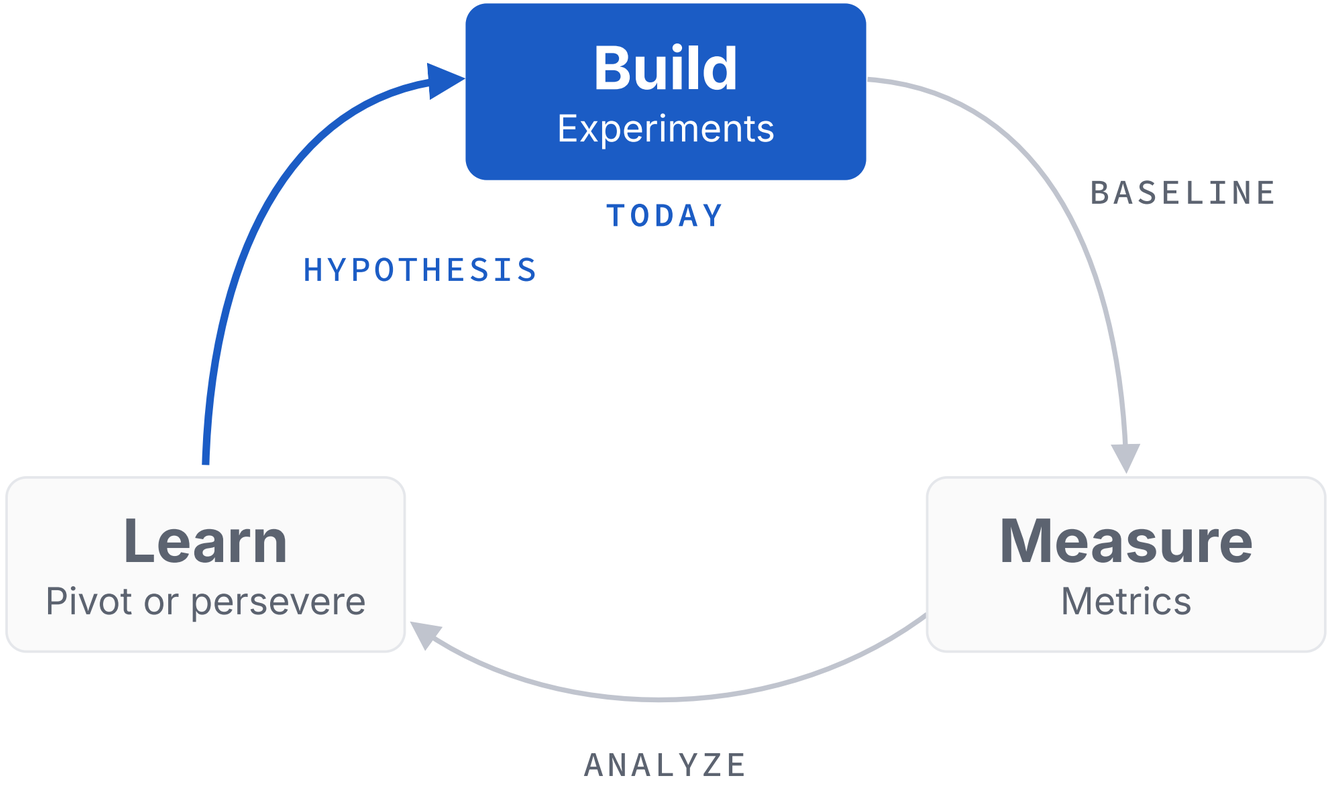
more revenue per firm over 16 months, many earned none

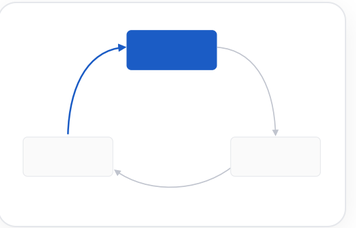
RESEARCH Camuffo et al. (2024), Strategic Management Journal, 759 firms. First trial: Camuffo et al. (2020), Management Science, 116 startups.

CORNERSTONE · BUILD-MEASURE-LEARN

Your idea is a **hypothesis**

Build the smallest test, measure, learn





THE PROBLEM HYPOTHESIS

Write hypotheses a stranger could prove wrong

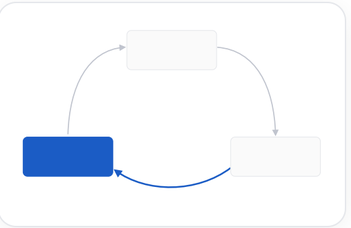
Who, problem, situation, workaround, cost

A SOLUTION IN DISGUISE

"People need an app that makes hiring easier."

A PROBLEM HYPOTHESIS

Junior HR managers struggle with candidates who ghost them after the interview. Today they chase by phone, which costs them [hours] a week.



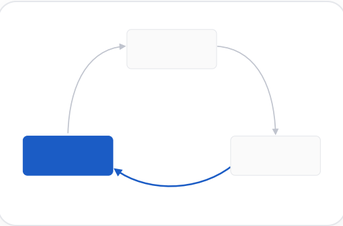
DISCIPLINED ENTREPRENEURSHIP · 24 STEPS

24 steps feel safe. It's still one loop

Each step is Build-Measure-Learn. Steps 20 and 21 meet reality

1 Market segmentation	**2** Select a beachhead market	**3** Build an end user profile	**4** TAM for the beachhead	**5** Persona for the beachhead	**6** Full life cycle use case
7 High-level product specification	**8** Quantify the value proposition	**9** Identify your next 10 customers	**10** Define your core	**11** Chart your competitive position	**12** Determine the customer organisation
13 Map how to acquire a paying customer	**14** TAM for follow-on markets	**15** Design a business model	**16** Set your pricing framework	**17** Calculate the unit economics	**18** Map the sales process
19 Calculate the customer economics	**20** Identify key assumptions	**21** Test key assumptions	**22** Define the MVP	**23** Prove your beachhead with your MVP	**24** Develop a product plan

FRAMEWORK Aulet, B. (2013). *Disciplined Entrepreneurship: 24 Steps to a Successful Startup*. Wiley. Step names as on legacy slide 39, shortened.



REALITY CHECK

Every plan feels safe until reality hits back



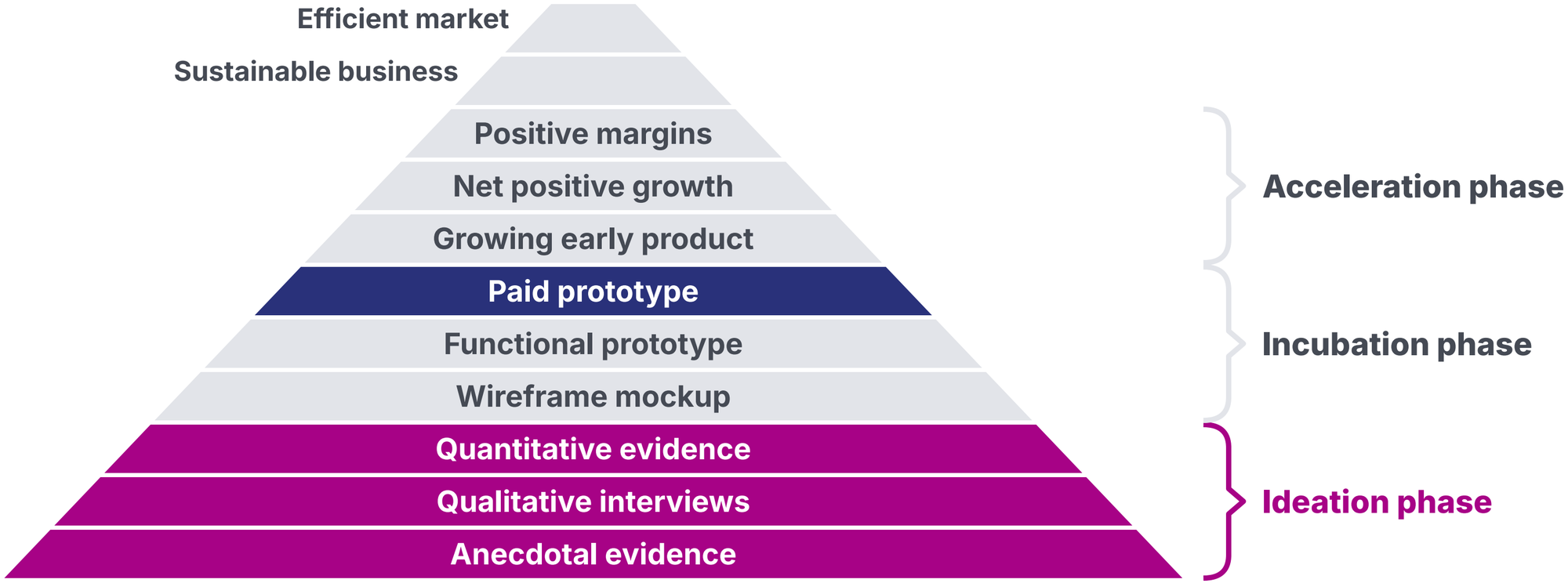
Everybody has a 24-step plan until reality punches them in the face.

After Mike Tyson

BASTIAN After Mike Tyson (1987), "Everybody has plans until they get hit for the first time." GIF from legacy slide 40.

CORNERSTONE · HIERARCHY OF EVIDENCE

It's a signal until somebody pays



HANDS UP · 1 MINUTE

What backs your idea today?

Rate the belief you wrote on the tier list

1. My opinion
2. An anecdote
3. A conversation
4. A payment

1:00

SPEED MATTERS

Speed matters:

Ship weekly

SPEED MATTERS

Every week, you can talk to at least

15 relevant users

15 a week is 3 a day.

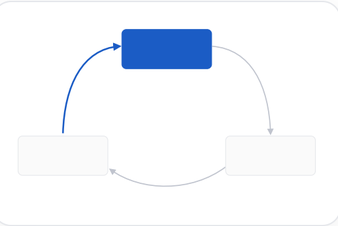
This week's full bar.

BASTIAN Legacy slide 45. Number from the M00 homework.

SPEED MATTERS

One step should not take more than

4 hours



NOW YOU · ALONE · 2 MINUTES

What's your fastest test on a real person?

! THIS WEEK

Before you build anything

The smallest thing that reaches a real person by Friday.

→ Who exactly? A name, not a segment
→ What do you ask or show them?
→ Which day do you do it?
→ Like: "Call three HR managers from my old company on Thursday"

Output One test, one name, one day

Minutes 2

2:00

CHAPTER 4 OF 6

How this course works

Thirteen weeks built for speed, ending with a team, a validated idea and first revenue.

01 ~~Why now, why you~~

02 ~~It has never been easy~~

03 ~~Speed matters~~

04 **How this course works**

05 Wrap-up and check-out

06 Workshop: autopsy your startup before it dies

COURSE PATH

Thirteen weeks from first leads to first euros

The best teams make more than **€10,000** in revenue along the way

00 **Kickoff**
your first sales leads

01 **Team & foundations**
one shared problem space

02 **Finding ideas**
the first names on your prospect list

03 **The problem space**
your first prospects

04 **Validating problems**
your first testers and buyers

05 **The solution space**
MVP spec + deployed Weekend Build

06 **Prototyping with AI**
deployed prototype + 10 non-friend reactions

07 **The kill decision**
provisional verdict

08 **Finding first users**
first revenue from strangers

09 **Prototype to product**
more revenue

10 **Product management**
more revenue

11 **Founder health**
more revenue

12 **Fundraising & demo day**
verified revenue

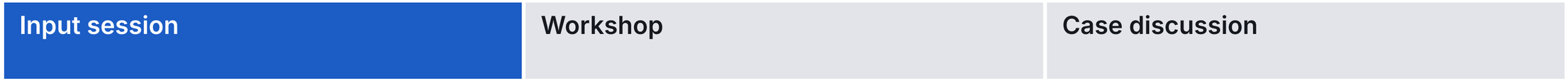
BASTIAN Week's goals of the module READMEs, 00 to 04 confirmed 2026-10-19. 05 to 07 the current weekly bars, from 08 on revenue without fixed amounts. The €10,000 line is Bastian's (2026-10-19).

HOW A WEEK RUNS

Every module offers three blocks

Each block works on its own

About 90 minutes each · drawn to scale



BLOCK	WHAT HAPPENS
Input session	Check-in, recap, your read-out, new content, wrap-up
Workshop	You start the week's work on your own venture
Case discussion	A real founder's decision, prepared at home in 4 to 6 hours

FROM MODULE 01 ON · EVERY WEEK

3:00

Show us where you're at in 3 minutes or less!

Start with your target against your actual

Facts

Statistics or research

What do they say?

What does it mean?

Where are they from?

Numbers

Usage or surveys

How were they reported?

How did they change?

Why is it relevant?

Quotes

Interviews or testimonials

What did they say?

Why did they say it?

What could this mean?

Images

Screenshots or users

What happened?

What changed?

Why is it relevant?

What did you do?

What did you learn?

How can we help?

EVERY WEEK

Every week, your target against your actual

1

User interactions?

What did you learn?

2

New revenue?

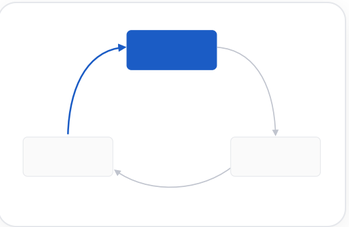
Why did they pay, or not?

3

What did you ship?

Why does it matter to them?

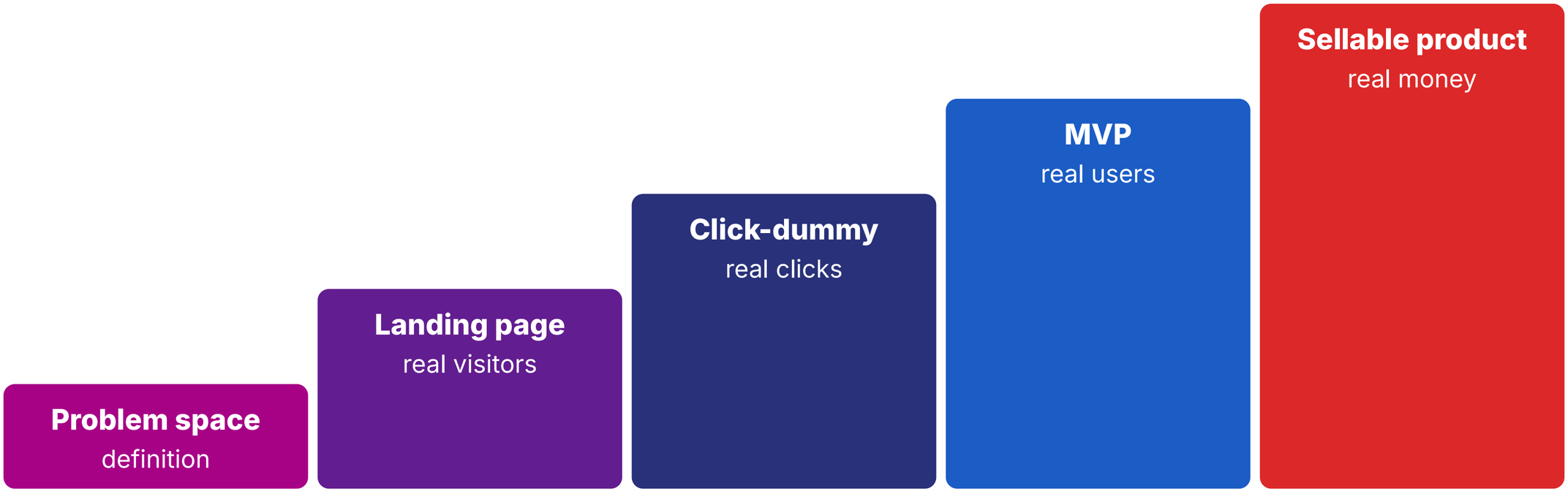
🦄 **Report target vs. actual. Say candidly why you hit it or missed it**



THE WORKSHOP LADDER

Your work climbs five rungs toward real users

Your results are for users to interact with



BASTIAN Workshops, legacy slide 16. "From concept to landing page, to product, to revenue", legacy slide 44.

HOW YOU'RE GRADED

Evidence and decisions weigh as much as revenue

You're not graded on sticking to your idea

The rubric · drawn to scale

Evidence quality	Decision discipline	Verified traction	Commu-nication
30%	30%	30%	10%

A well-argued kill with a documented evidence pack can earn an A.

A VERY GOOD RESULT IS A GROWING STARTUP

Work on what you control

Things you can control

- 😍 Talk to 15 users each week
- 📈 Present your progress every week and ask for help
- 🎁 Offer critical feedback and questions
- 🔬 Be an expert in your problem space
- 🔄 Pivot when you hit a brick wall

Things you can't totally control

- 🖥️ Steady growth on your landing page
- 📇 A lead list of potential users
- 🤑 Paying customers

BASTIAN Legacy slide 47. "15 to 20 users" set to the homework's 15, "3 times" to every week.

HOW WE WORK TOGETHER

Be present or be elsewhere

1

Together we grow: coachability

We give candid and productive feedback. We listen and seek to understand.

2

We act as we say: accountability

We stick to our word where it's in our hands. We learn from failures where it's not.

3

Give first, dream first: bias to action

We prefer building and experimenting over understanding every aspect.

DOS AND DON'TS IN THIS SEMINAR

Pivoting is fine. A knowingly bad idea isn't

Totally fine

- 🦄 Building wild ideas
- 😵‍💫 Regrouping
- 😉 Pivoting
- 😵 Failing

Not OK in here

- 👻 Sticking with a knowingly bad idea
- ⏰ Being late
- 🛌 Missing class
- 🤐 Staying silent when you don't understand

WHAT YOU LEAVE WITH

A team, a validated idea and first revenue

The best teams make more than €10,000 along the way

Team

2 to 4 people who commit to each other

Idea

validated: somebody paid for it

€

first revenue in the bank

BASTIAN Bastian's course goal (2026-10-19). "Validated" as in the course glossary (GLOSSARY.md): somebody opens their wallet.

WHAT WE ARE WORKING TOWARDS · THE SEQUOIA PITCH

Every phase earns part of your pitch

1	Company purpose	COVER
2	Problem	PROBLEM
3	Solution	SOLUTION
4	Why now?	PROBLEM
5	Market potential	COVER
6	Competition	PROBLEM
7	Business model	SOLUTION
8	Team	COVER
9	Financials	
10	Vision	
11	Roadmap	COVER

FRAMEWORK Sequoia Capital (2019), Writing a business plan, ten sections. Legacy slides 89 to 95, plus Bastian's roadmap.

TEAMS FORM IN MODULE 01

Find teammates this week, or we match you

4a

Find teammates

Say your problem space in one sentence

Talk to the people who share it, this week

4b

We match you

Nobody found by Module 01?

We match you on your problem space

BASTIAN Participation and team allocation, legacy slide 13. Teams commit in Module 01 (2026-10-19).

CHAPTER 5 OF 6

Wrap-up and check-out

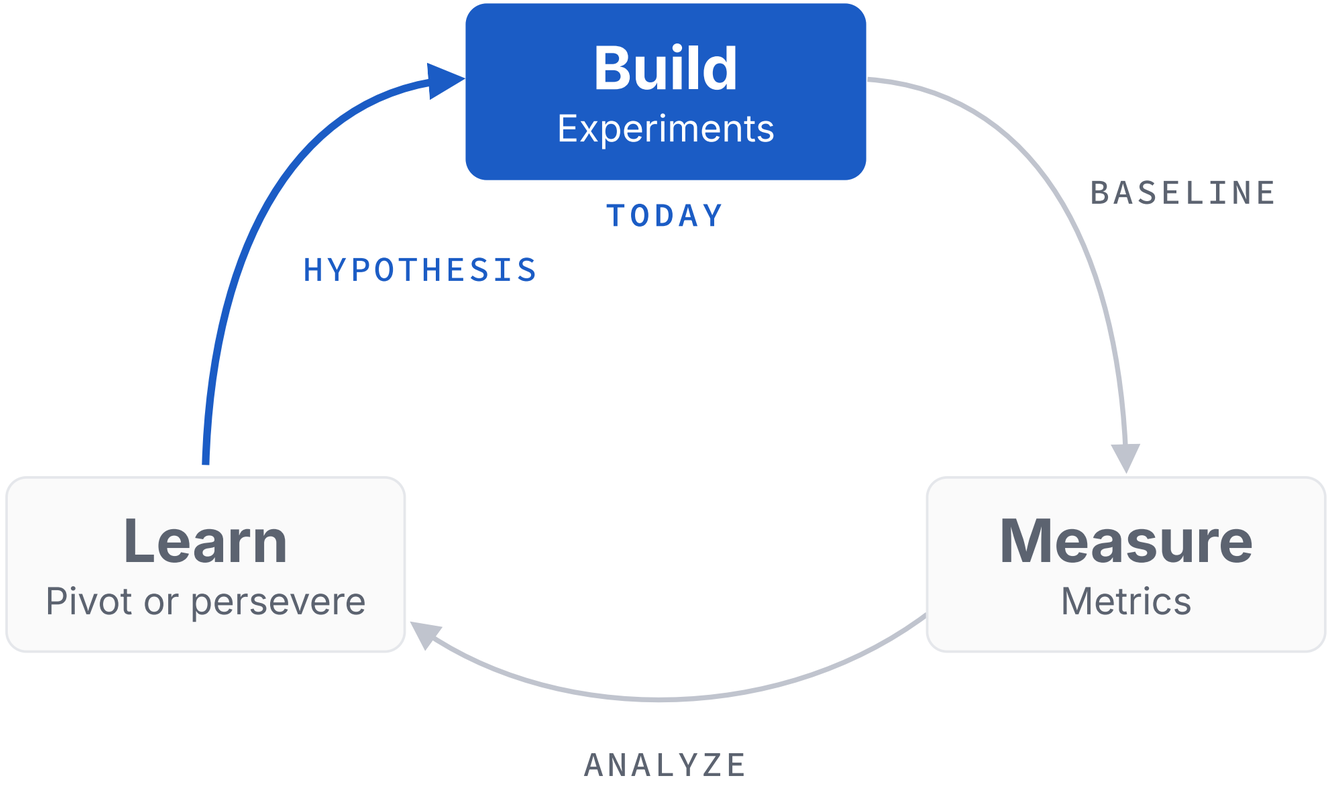
What you take home today, and the fifteen conversations that start this week.

01 ~~Why now, why you~~
02 ~~It has never been easy~~
03 ~~Speed matters~~
04 ~~How this course works~~
05 **Wrap-up and check-out**
06 Workshop: autopsy your startup before it dies

RECAP · CORNERSTONE

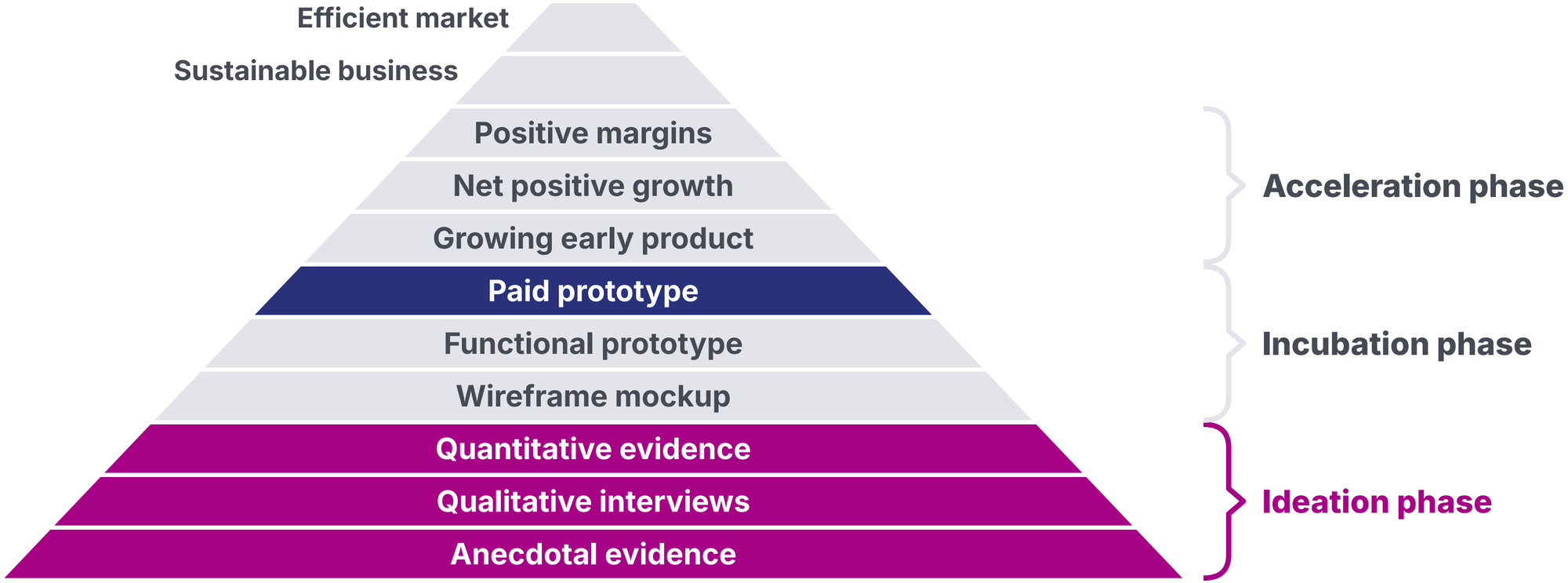
One full turn this week, not this semester

You started today. Close it by Module 01



RECAP · CORNERSTONE

Climb from opinions to a payment



BASTIAN Hierarchy of evidence in the lean startup, legacy slide 60.

REFLECTION 1 OF 3 · THE CONTENT

What could you apply?



What could you apply?



What gave you a hard time?

REFLECTION 2 OF 3 · THE PROCESS

Man vs. machine



Where did AI actually help you?



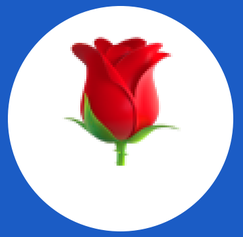
Where was your genius needed?



What are your best hacks to share?

REFLECTION 3 OF 3 · THE RESULTS

Rose, thorn, bud



What was the breakthrough today?



What was the hardest part today?



What is an idea/feature you didn't have time to finish, but want to explore later?

HOMEWORK UNTIL MODULE 01

Write 3 problem hypotheses and hold 15 problem conversations with named people, learning what the problem costs each of them today, and come back with 3 people who agreed to a next step.

15 conversations

The learning floor is 3 hypotheses and 5 conversations with 1 next step.

Log your kill line before your first conversation.

HOMEWORK · HOW TO

Find your people where they already are

Fifteen conversations means three a day. Start today

1

People you see every day

Colleagues, clients, your lab. What do they complain about, and whom do they know?

2

Be a fly on the wall

Sit in on a shift or a support queue. Note what people curse at

3

Read bad reviews

1 to 3 stars on Trustpilot, G2 or Capterra. Repeated complaints are problems

4

AI deep research

Ask where your "who" complains online

HOMEWORK · WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE

Dig deeper, or move on

A narrow, deep well: a few people want it fixed badly. A made-up example

	DIG DEEPER	MOVE ON
Who	Lab managers in biotech start-ups	"Researchers"
Raised	4 of 10, before I named it	Only once I named it
Cost	4 hours a week, 2 built Excel trackers	"Annoying, but we live with it"
How many	6 of 10, in 4 labs	Me and my flatmate

ILLUSTRATIVE M00 homework, "What you come back with", made-up example. "Narrow, deep well" after Graham (2012).

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See you in Module 01, with names and numbers!

MODULE 00 · WORKSHOP · 90 MINUTES

Workshop: Autopsy your startup before it dies

Find what could kill your idea, write hypotheses you can lose, and reach real people today.

What kills startups, and what will this course demand from you?

01 ~~Why now, why you~~
02 ~~It has never been easy~~
03 ~~Speed matters~~
04 ~~How this course works~~
05 ~~Wrap-up and check-out~~
06 **Workshop: autopsy your startup before it dies**

WORKSHOP · STEP 1 OF 3

Autopsy your own startup

1 STEP 1 · 25 MIN

AUTOPSY YOUR OWN STARTUP

Find the customer assumption that kills your idea

→ Your starting point in one line
→ One year on, your startup is dead. Why?
→ Each cause becomes "We assumed ..."
→ Circle the riskiest untested one
→ Pairs: "How do you know?"

Output Riskiest untested assumption, in the Weekly Reflection

Minutes 25

25:00

WORKSHOP · STEP 2 OF 3

Write hypotheses you can lose

2 STEP 2 · 25 MIN

WRITE HYPOTHESES YOU CAN LOSE

Hypotheses a stranger could prove wrong this week

→ 3 hypotheses: who, problem, situation, workaround, cost
→ Rate the evidence: opinion, anecdote, conversation, payment
→ Rank them, riskiest first, start AI deep research
→ Kill line logged before any contact

Output 3 ranked hypotheses, their evidence, a kill line

Minutes 25

25:00

WORKSHOP · STEP 3 OF 3

Reach real people, then commit

3 STEP 3 · 40 MIN

REACH REAL PEOPLE, THEN COMMIT

Leave with the week already moving

→ 10 min: pick named people from your research
→ 15 min: 5 messages to named people, or one call
→ Don't name your problem, do NOT pitch
→ 10 min: floor or full bar, midweek pace
→ 5 min: your problem space in one sentence, find teammates

Output Messages sent, target, pace, possible teammates

Minutes 40

40:00

ARRIVED EMPTY-HANDED?

No idea yet? Run the autopsy on a frustration you watched someone fight last month.

1 real frustration

HOMEWORK UNTIL MODULE 01

Write 3 problem hypotheses and hold 15 problem conversations with named people, learning what the problem costs each of them today, and come back with 3 people who agreed to a next step.

15 conversations

The learning floor is 3 hypotheses and 5 conversations with 1 next step.

Log your kill line before your first conversation.

See you in Module 01, with names and numbers!